

# Prefixes and suffixes

PREFIXES AND SUFFIXES ARE COLLECTIVELY CALLED AFFIXES.

Prefixes are added to the start of a word and suffixes are added to the end of a word. They can change a word's meaning or its part of speech, or—combined with a partial root word—create a new word.

## Prefixes

A prefix is added to the start of a root to change the meaning of that root or create a new word. For example, the root word *do* acquires the opposite meaning when the prefix *un-* (meaning “not”) is added, resulting in the word *undo*. When the prefix *demo-* (meaning “common people” in Greek) is added to the partial root *crat* (meaning “rule” in Greek), it results in the whole English word *democrat*. Other prefixes can be added to the root *crat* to form the English words *aristocrat*, *autocrat*, and *bureaucrat*.

### SEE ALSO

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| ◀ 136–137                               | Morphemes |
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| Words ending in -le, -el, -al, or -ol   | 152–153 ▶ |
| Single and double consonant words       | 154–155 ▶ |



• Most **prefixes** are not separated from the root by a **hyphen**. However, **ex-** (as in “former”) and **self-** are **always** followed by a **hyphen**.

| Prefixes                     | Meaning      | Examples                                             |
|------------------------------|--------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>a-, an-</b>               | not          | <b>atypical, anonymous</b>                           |
| <b>ab-</b>                   | away from    | <b>abnormal</b>                                      |
| <b>ad-</b>                   | toward       | <b>advance</b>                                       |
| <b>al-</b>                   | all          | <b>almost</b>                                        |
| <b>all-</b>                  | all          | <b>all-knowing</b>                                   |
| <b>ante-</b>                 | before       | <b>anteroom</b>                                      |
| <b>anti-</b>                 | against      | <b>antisocial</b>                                    |
| <b>be-</b>                   | make         | <b>befriend</b>                                      |
| <b>co-, col-, com-, con-</b> | together     | <b>cooperate, collaborate, community, confidence</b> |
| <b>de-</b>                   | opposite     | <b>detach</b>                                        |
| <b>de-</b>                   | down         | <b>decline</b>                                       |
| <b>dis-</b>                  | not          | <b>disembark</b>                                     |
| <b>em-, en-</b>              | cause to     | <b>embattle, enamor</b>                              |
| <b>ex-</b>                   | out of, from | <b>export</b>                                        |
| <b>ex-</b>                   | former       | <b>ex-husband</b>                                    |
| <b>extra-</b>                | beyond       | <b>extraordinary</b>                                 |
| <b>fore-</b>                 | before       | <b>forearm</b>                                       |
| <b>im-, in-</b>              | in           | <b>import, income</b>                                |
| <b>im-, in-, ir-</b>         | not          | <b>immature, incredible, irrational</b>              |
| <b>inter-</b>                | among        | <b>international</b>                                 |
| <b>intra-</b>                | within       | <b>intramural</b>                                    |

| Prefixes            | Meaning          | Examples                     |
|---------------------|------------------|------------------------------|
| <b>intro-</b>       | in               | <b>introduction</b>          |
| <b>mid-</b>         | middle           | <b>midway</b>                |
| <b>mis-</b>         | wrongly          | <b>misconception</b>         |
| <b>non-</b>         | not              | <b>nonsense</b>              |
| <b>out-</b>         | more than others | <b>outstanding</b>           |
| <b>out-</b>         | separate         | <b>outhouse</b>              |
| <b>over-</b>        | too much         | <b>overdo</b>                |
| <b>para-</b>        | beyond, beside   | <b>paranormal</b>            |
| <b>per-</b>         | through          | <b>perform</b>               |
| <b>post-</b>        | after            | <b>postwar</b>               |
| <b>pre-</b>         | before           | <b>premature</b>             |
| <b>pro-</b>         | for              | <b>proactive</b>             |
| <b>re-</b>          | again            | <b>reapply</b>               |
| <b>retro-</b>       | back             | <b>retrospective</b>         |
| <b>se-</b>          | away from        | <b>segregate</b>             |
| <b>self-</b>        | oneself          | <b>self-confidence</b>       |
| <b>sub-</b>         | under            | <b>submarine</b>             |
| <b>super-, sur-</b> | over, above      | <b>supernatural, survive</b> |
| <b>sus-</b>         | under            | <b>suspect</b>               |
| <b>trans-</b>       | across           | <b>transmit</b>              |
| <b>ultra-</b>       | beyond           | <b>ultrasound</b>            |
| <b>un-</b>          | not              | <b>uncover</b>               |
| <b>under-</b>       | beneath, below   | <b>undermine</b>             |